Decoding Quality Performance

Applying ISO 9001 2026: from business priorities to verified results



A practical guide and workbook for quality practitioners and business leaders

Rafal Pereszczako | First edition November 2026

World Quality Week companion edition

Using this workbook

Use this workbook to choose a worthwhile improvement, build credible evidence and decide whether to close the work or continue. Involve a process owner, an operational colleague and an objective evidence reviewer.

Start with a recurring business problem and finish with an evidence supported decision on performance, residual risk and the next review. The guide explains the method and supplies adaptable records.

Scope and technical basis

ISO 9001:2026 sets the management-system context. This independent RPG Excellence guide neither reproduces the standard nor provides a complete transition checklist. Its worksheets, example thresholds and review arrangements are suggested practices, not additional ISO requirements. Check conformity against your licensed standard and applicable customer and regulatory requirements.

World Quality Week 2026 runs from 9 to 13 November with the CQI theme Quality: powering performance [1]. ISO's public overview highlights leadership, culture, strategic alignment, risk and opportunity [2]. ISO 10014 provides complementary guidance on financial and economic benefits [3].

How to work through the guide

Read sections 1 - 9 for the method, then use sections 10 - 16 to conduct a focused improvement review. Keep original evidence in your controlled system and record its location in the worksheets. Finish with a decision, an owner and a review date.

All numerical examples are fictional. They illustrate plausible analysis, not RPG customer results, industry benchmarks or guaranteed benefits.

1 Choose a business priority

Choose a problem that customers and operational leaders recognise. Late reports, repeat corrections, avoidable rework and unreliable supplier deliveries are easier to investigate than a broad aim to improve the QMS.

Specify where the problem occurs and what it affects. Distinguish observations from assumed causes: “staff lack awareness” is a hypothesis; “100 of 1,000 issued reports needed correction” is an observation if the counting rules are clear.

Write a useful problem statement

Describe the process, period, measured problem and affected customer or business outcome. State the evidence source and its limitations.

Example: From April to June, 100 of 1,000 service reports needed correction after issue, delaying customer acceptance and consuming engineering capacity. The dataset excludes reports cancelled before issue.

Select work leadership can support

Identify who is affected, which objective is at risk, what the team can influence and who can authorise change. Supplier issues may involve Purchasing and Engineering; document errors may involve Sales, Operations and Quality.

Agree the sponsor and process owner early. The sponsor removes barriers and approves resources; the process owner remains accountable for operations. Quality can facilitate investigation and evidence review without owning every operational control.

Output: a clearly bounded problem, an accountable process owner and a business reason to act.

2 Establish a defensible baseline

A baseline captures performance before a change. Choose a period that reflects normal operations and provides enough relevant opportunities to observe the problem. A convenient calendar month may not suit rare events or seasonal processes.

Define the numerator and denominator. Specify whether you count defective reports, individual defects or customer complaints. A report may contain several defects, so these measures answer different questions.

Field	What to define
Population	Reports, orders, services or units included
Event	Criteria defining a correction, failure or delay
Exposure	Denominator, such as issued reports, operating hours or deliveries
Period	Start and end dates, with shutdown exclusions
Source	Source system, extraction date and record owner
Comparability	Work complexity, customer mix, staffing and process changes

Check the records before using the percentage

Check a sample against original records for duplicates, missing completion dates and coding changes. Keep the original extract and document cleaning decisions. If records are incomplete, disclose the limitation and plan further collection rather than implying precision.

Use time ordered data where possible: averages can conceal deterioration or brief improvement. A few observations cannot establish stability. Seek suitable statistical advice when variation or control limits affect a material decision.

Output: a reproducible definition and dataset another reviewer can follow.

3 Connect the management system

View the QMS as interconnected processes. Errors found at final review may begin in contract requirements, supplier information, technical handovers or decisions made under delivery pressure.

This clause-family map guides application and enquiry. It neither reproduces requirements nor suggests that every practice is new in 2026.

ISO 9001 area	Useful performance enquiry
4 Context	Which customer and business needs make the problem significant?
5 Leadership	Who owns the outcome, and which decisions support it?
6 Planning	Which risks, opportunities and intended results shape the change?
7 Support	Are knowledge, competence, resources and communication sufficient?
8 Operation	Where should controls prevent or detect the failure?
9 Evaluation	Which evidence supports conclusions and leadership decisions?
10 Improvement	Has the cause been addressed and the improvement sustained?

Follow one real case

Follow a report or order from initial requirements to customer acceptance. Compare documented procedures with actual work. Speak to people at handovers, examine the information they receive and identify informal workarounds for missing or unreliable controls.

Identify the decision or control that needs to change before designing a form. A form helps only when its information is used where it matters.

Output: a brief account of the process and the controls affecting its result.

4 Investigate the cause

Contain immediate customer or product risks while investigating the cause, but keep the two activities distinct. Checking a batch may protect the customer without explaining how the failure arose or escaped detection.

Use process mapping, interviews, record review, cause-and-effect analysis or structured questioning as appropriate. Support each proposed cause with evidence. A completed diagram records the team's thinking; it does not prove the conclusion.

Test competing explanations

Report corrections may stem from incomplete customer requirements, weak template controls, inaccessible technical knowledge, ineffective review or workload pressure. Compare error cases with error free cases and check whether the suspected condition consistently explains the pattern.

When human performance is involved, examine information, tools, workload, competence and decision conditions. Telling someone to be more careful does little to prevent recurrence.

Link each action to a cause

Explain why each action should work. If uncontrolled template selection caused the problem, training alone leaves that choice uncontrolled. A governed template source and proportionate checks may be stronger, but must be tested in practice.

Before implementation, decide how to identify an ineffective change. Set an escalation trigger if corrections persist and retain interim controls where risk requires them.

Output: an evidence-supported cause, an action that addresses it and a clear explanation of the expected effect.

5 Choose measures that support decisions

Choose a few measures with distinct purposes: an outcome measure for results, a control use measure for implementation and a balancing measure for unwanted effects elsewhere.

Purpose	Report correction example	Decision supported
Outcome	Reports corrected after issue / issued reports	Is customer facing performance improving?
Control use	Eligible reports using the governed template / all eligible reports	Is the change in use?
Control quality	Sampled reviews meeting acceptance criteria / all sampled reviews	Is review quality sufficient?
Balancing	Median and upper-range report turnaround time	Is the change delaying delivery?
Business effect	Correction hours per 100 issued reports	Has the demand for rework fallen?

“Leading” and “lagging” are relative terms. Review completion may precede a customer outcome, but evidence must still show that the review is useful. Completion rates alone can encourage superficial checks.

Set thresholds before seeing the result

Set the intended performance, minimum observation period and escalation conditions in advance. Base them on exposure, risk and the operating cycle, not arbitrary targets copied from another organisation.

Give each measure an owner. Define collection frequency, exclusions and the response to performance changes. Measures that support no decision can become reporting overhead.

Output: defined outcome, control and balancing measures with clear decision rules.

6 Read improvement claims carefully



Completing an action shows implementation. Effectiveness requires evidence that the control addresses the identified cause. A business outcome requires an additional link to customer or operational performance.

Ask three questions: Is the change in place? Does it work? What result has changed? An implementation record may answer only the first.

Acknowledge when evidence is insufficient. For rare events, a short period without recurrence may reveal little. Test the control directly and arrange a longer outcome review where appropriate.

Keep necessary interim controls beyond administrative deadlines. Record the residual risk, who accepts it and when it will be reviewed.

7 Work through a numerical example

In this fictional service business, the team introduces a governed report template and a clearer technical review step, then compares two periods. The calculation supports investigation; it does not prove causation.

Measure	Before	After
Reports issued	1,000	800
Reports corrected after issue	100	48
Correction rate	10.0%	6.0%
First time acceptance	90.0%	94.0%

The correction rate falls from 100 / 1,000 = 10% to 48 / 800 = 6%: an improvement of 4 percentage points. The relative rate reduction is (10% − 6%) / 10% = 40%.

Corrections fell by 52 reports, but output also declined. Calling this a 52% performance improvement would confuse counts with rates. At the baseline rate, 800 reports would produce 80 corrections. The 48 observed corrections are 32 fewer on this simple volume adjusted basis.

Check alternative explanations

Was the later work simpler? Did customer requirements or error definitions change? Were more corrections made before issue, or fewer recorded? Check these alternatives before attributing the full change to the intervention.

A proportion alone does not show uncertainty or normal variation. Plot consecutive periods, check exposure and seek suitable statistical support before making material investment or capability claims.

Output: a clear separation of counts, rates, percentage-point differences and relative change.

8 Translate results into business value

Continuing the fictional example, assume an avoided correction releases 1.5 hours at an agreed loaded labour rate of £40 per hour. The volume adjusted reduction of 32 corrections represents 48 hours, valued at £1,920 for the observed period.

Calculation	Result
800 reports × 10% baseline rate	80 expected corrections
80 expected minus 48 observed	32 fewer corrections
32 × 1.5 hours	48 hours of capacity
48 × £40 per hour	£1,920 valued capacity

Valued capacity is not automatically a £1,920 cash saving. If paid hours stay unchanged, the benefit may be time available for other useful work. Cash savings need evidence of lower expenditure, such as avoided paid overtime, and appropriate financial validation.

Include the cost of the intervention

Assume the added review takes 0.025 hours per report: 20 hours for 800 reports, valued at £800 on the same basis. Net recurring capacity is 28 hours, valued at £1,120, before implementation costs and other effects. These illustrative assumptions need local validation.

Distinguish one-off design, training and system costs from recurring costs. Do not count the same hours as both labour savings and added revenue. Additional revenue also depends on demand, constraints and contribution margin.

Output: a transparent account of benefits, assumptions, costs and benefit classification, with Finance review where material.

9 Examine everyday leadership decisions



Quality culture becomes visible when people flag discrepancies before dispatch or challenge incomplete approvals. Examine what follows: who decides, how the concern is handled and whether the person receives useful feedback.

Fewer reported concerns may mean fewer problems or less confidence in reporting. Check the context before celebrating. An initial increase may reflect better visibility, not poorer performance.

Use brief discussions and case reviews to examine delivery pressure, escalation and decision authority. Clarify how to handle conflicting requirements and address the practical barriers people identify.

Record observable decisions and improvements. One survey score cannot establish a strong quality culture. Check experiences across shifts, locations and employment groups.

10 Plan effectiveness verification

Plan verification before implementing the action. Select evidence that can reveal failure as well as success. The reviewer should be able to challenge the action owner's conclusion and inspect original records.

For the report example, verification could combine checks of template selection, a sample of completed technical reviews and trends in post issue correction rates. Define coverage across report types, people and operating conditions. Match sample size to risk and population; this workbook sets no universal number.

Choose an appropriate observation period

Allow enough relevant exposure and a representative operating cycle. Thirty days may support an initial implementation check, but not a rare failure, annual activity or seasonal demand. Extend observation and retain proportionate controls when evidence is limited.

Decision	Evidence and response
Effective	Criteria met, with evidence linking cause and control; keep monitoring
Partially effective	Benefits shown, but gaps remain; keep controls and assign further action
Ineffective	Criteria not met or recurrence reveals weakness; revisit the cause and escalate
Insufficient evidence	Too little exposure or inadequate records; specify further checks and a review date

Independent review can strengthen governance in significant cases. Tailor the arrangements to risk, customer obligations and management-system rules; no particular job title is universally required.

Output: a justified decision supported by evidence references, residual risk and a trigger for further review.

11 Bring a decision to management review

Give leaders the evidence to decide whether a process needs resources, revised controls or further investigation. A completed task list rarely provides enough information.

Use a concise evidence narrative

Set out the customer or business problem, baseline and measurement rules. Explain the cause, the change and its operating cost. Show outcome, control-use and balancing measures together, with uncertainty and residual risk.

Request a clear decision for example, approve a controlled rollout to a second report family, retain the interim check for one more operating cycle or fund analysis of the unresolved handover issue.

Avoid confident statements the data cannot support

A better month alone does not demonstrate sustained improvement. An on-time audit does not prove process effectiveness, nor does an error-free sample guarantee correct future reports. Explain what the evidence supports and what remains to be tested.

Record the decision, reasons, accountable owner and review date. Leadership’s acceptance of residual risk must be explicit and made by someone with appropriate authority. Legal and contractual obligations still apply.

Suggested discussion

How has the customer’s experience changed? What evidence links the result to the intervention? What was the cost? What could reverse the improvement? Which decision is needed today?

Output: an authorised decision that can be implemented and reviewed.

12 Run a focused improvement cycle

Start one practical review during World Quality Week. This 30-day schedule mobilises the work; it does not promise proof of effectiveness within a month.

Timing	Activity	Deliverable
Days 1-5	Choose the problem and sponsor; set scope and evidence sources	Agreed problem and plan for the baseline
Days 6-10	Trace cases, investigate causes and assess data quality	Explanation supported by evidence
Days 11-15	Choose the intervention, assess risk and define verification criteria	Approved change and verification plan
Days 16-25	Introduce and observe controls; collect initial measures	Evidence of implementation and issues identified
Days 26-30	Assess initial results and remaining uncertainty	Decision and schedule for longer-term review

Before changing a live process, assess effects on customer approvals, technical authority, competence, records, supplier interfaces and other controls. Define the trial's owner and boundaries, with rollback or containment arrangements where needed.

Hold a weekly evidence discussion

Ask what the team has learned and what could change its conclusion. Highlight information gaps, allow time for checks and encourage reporting of difficulties. Escalate resource or authority gaps before actions become overdue.

At day 30, report progress briefly, distinguishing implemented changes from verified outcomes. Continue verification for the agreed exposure period, adjusting it when evidence supports a change.

Output: a manageable improvement, clear governance and a candid progress report.

13 Worksheet for the improvement brief

Develop this brief with the process owner. Define the observed problem before choosing a solution. Use the ruled space for notes and keep the approved brief in your controlled records.

Customer or business problem

State the process, period and observed impact.

_____

Scope and exclusions

List the included sites, products, services and interfaces.

_____

Baseline and source

Specify the numerator, denominator and data owner.

_____

Intended result

Define the intended outcome and balancing condition.

_____

Accountability

Identify the sponsor, process owner, action owners and reviewer.

_____

Constraints and authority

Note customer approvals, resources, risks and limits of authority.

_____

Approval check: confirm that the sponsor and process owner agree on the purpose, measures and authority to approve changes.

14 Worksheet for a measure definition

Complete a separate copy for each measure. Someone outside the project should be able to repeat the calculation and understand the decision it informs.

Measure name and purpose

Explain the outcome or control being measured.

_____

Calculation and counting rules

Specify numerator, denominator, units and inclusion and exclusion rules.

_____

Data provenance

Identify the system, source records, extraction method and owner.

_____

Baseline and comparability

Specify the period, exposure, complexity and known limitations.

_____

Target and escalation

Define the intended result and triggers for action.

_____

Reporting and decision

Specify reporting frequency, reviewer, response and record location.

_____

Integrity check: make duplicates, missing records and definition changes visible. Keep the original extract and calculation method.

15 Worksheet for verification and closure

Prepare the plan before implementation and record findings at review. If exposure is insufficient for closure, identify the additional evidence needed.

Cause and intervention

State the cause, supporting evidence and why the action should work.

_____

Acceptance criteria

Set thresholds for control performance, outcomes and balancing measures.

_____

Evidence and exposure

Define records, coverage, operating conditions and observation period.

_____

Results and exceptions

Document findings, recurrence, limitations and unintended effects.

_____

Decision and residual risk

Choose effective, partially effective, ineffective or insufficient evidence, and justify the decision.

_____

Authorisation and follow up

Identify the reviewer and decision owner; set a review date or trigger.

_____

Closure check: confirm traceable evidence references, an authorised decision and an owner for continuing work. Follow your controlled procedure for administrative closure.

16 Worksheet for the leadership decision

Write a brief decision paper using the project's measurement definitions. Make benefit assumptions explicit and seek financial review of material claims.

Problem and strategic relevance

State the customer impact and affected business objective.

_____

Change and demonstrated outcome

Outline the baseline, change, result and strength of evidence.

_____

Benefits and costs

Distinguish cash savings, released capacity, cost avoidance and implementation costs.

_____

Remaining risk and uncertainty

Note constraints, conflicting evidence and risks to sustained improvement.

_____

Decision requested

Specify the proposed option, resources and authority needed.

_____

Decision and next review

Document approval or rejection, reasons, owner and review date.

_____

Meeting check: identify who will communicate the decision and how affected people can report implementation issues.

17 Publish an evidence based improvement story

A useful World Quality Week story explains what happened and what colleagues can learn. Describe the problem and change, then report the result with its denominator and period.

Fictional example: After a governed template and review change, post-issue corrections fell from 10% of 1,000 reports to 6% of 800. This initial comparison suggests improvement. The team is checking the report mix and monitoring performance before judging the result sustained.

This account is more informative than a claim of dramatic transformation because it shows both scale and limitations. Exclude customer and personal information unless authorised, and obtain appropriate approval before publishing business results.

Use the posters to start a discussion

Use Poster 1 as a newsletter cover or discussion opener on quality and performance. Poster 2 explores the gap between completed actions and demonstrated improvement. Poster 3 prompts discussion of leadership decisions under pressure.

After showing a poster, ask: Which current improvement could we explain with evidence this strong? Assign someone to bring the supporting record to the next review.

Applying the approach with RPG Excellence

RPG Excellence offers practical tools for assessments, audits, findings, actions and effectiveness review. Keep evidence and ownership linked in a controlled workspace. Useful results still depend on local processes, competence and sound decisions.

Find the platform and practitioner resources at https://www.rpgexcellence.com, and the ISO 9001 guide and assessment resources at https://www.rpgexcellence.com/en/iso-9001.

Sources and publication information

Rafal Pereszczako | RPG Excellence | Practitioner Series | First edition November 2026

© 2026 RPG Excellence. Original explanatory text, worksheets and poster designs. ISO and CQI names refer to their respective organisations. This independent publication does not imply their endorsement.

Primary references

[1] CQI. How will you celebrate World Quality Week 2026. https://www.quality.org/how-will-you-celebrate-wqw-2026

[2] ISO. ISO 9001 2026 What businesses need to know. https://www.iso.org/quality-management/iso-9001-2026

[3] ISO. ISO 10014 2021 Financial and economic benefits. https://www.iso.org/standard/75233.html

Source pages checked on 4 November 2026. This workbook interprets only the topics covered. Consult the licensed ISO 9001:2026 text for normative requirements and the contractual and regulatory provisions applicable to your activities.

How to interpret the examples

All sample data, costs, timings and thresholds are illustrative, not customer testimonials or validated industry benchmarks. The report example measures the proportion of reports needing correction, not individual defects. The financial example values capacity at an assumed loaded labour rate and deducts an assumed recurring review cost.

This RPG practice framework sets no universal sampling rule, mandatory review period or guaranteed investment return. Use judgement proportionate to the process, risk and evidence quality.

Poster reuse

Purchasers may use the three supplied posters for internal awareness and to share the RPG Excellence article with attribution. This permission neither transfers ownership nor allows resale of the poster files as standalone products.